ing more content-driven films". "They were doing good business, but even that was restricted to upper strata, to the cities," he adds. The commercial potboilers became few and far between in the recent past, with only Salman Khan and filmmaker Rohit Shetty contributing films with mass appeal. (It took Shetty's *Sooryavanshi* in November 2021 for the Hindi film industry to finally recover from the blows of Covid-19 pandemic.) Deprived thus, the Hindi film audience began to get their entertainment fix elsewhere. "It's a visual treat to just watch them," says Thadani. "The kind of money they spend to build the scale of the film, how they shoot it, they are big-screen entertainers.

SOUTHWARD -BOUND

Bollywood is looking with awe. In an SMS that went viral, Rajkumar Hirani lauded *Pushpa* creator Sukumar for making an "excellent film". "I have been talking about it to so many people that they are wondering what's wrong with me," wrote Hirani, who has delivered his share of blockbusters with barely any stunt sequences. "I loved the writing...how you have turned every scene on its head to make it unusual. It's shot well... It's a great entertainer." Sukumar, though, wasn't confident of the film's prospects in Hindi-speaking territories, worried that the producers would incur losses for there'd hardly be any takers for a story centred on a rugged, lungi-wearing hero and a heroine in South Indian attire. Asked what made the Telugu film a box-office frontrunner then, Sukumar says, "We didn't leave the commercial film. It's always happening here. You have to give a mixture of songs, fights, romance, laughs and heroism. It's like a garland made of different flowers. It keeps us connected to all of India."

Hindi stars have begun looking southwards. Alia Bhatt settled for a brief cameo in *RRR* just to work with the visionary S.S. Rajamouli. Shah Rukh Khan is collaborating with Atlee (*Mersal*, *Bigil*) on *Jawan* (2023); Ranveer Singh has announced a project with the blockbuster-generator Shankar (*Indian*, *Sivaji: the Boss*, *Enthiran*) and Deepika Padukone, too, has been working in Hyderabad with Prabhas on *Mahanati* filmmaker Nag Ashwin's next. Streaming platforms have only added to the fan base of actors like Fahadh Faasil and Vijay Sethupathi, both acclaimed for their thespian skills.

While Mumbai-based studios have begun roping in filmmakers from the South to do remakes, those in the South are increasingly emboldened by their success in the Hindi belt. Chaluve Gowda, a partner at Hombale Films, which produced the KGF franchise, says that the quip in Kannada industry circles was that they spent more on marketing than on production. But the at-

LEADING LADIES

FEMALE ACTORS WHOSE FAN FOLLOWING RIVALS THE MEN'S



Samantha: After a quiet but fierce act in Season 2 of *The Family Man*, her sensuous turn in the *Pushpa* earworm, 'Oo Antava Oo Oo Antava', had audiences asking for more. Next up, the Indian edition of Amazon Prime Video series *Citadel*



Keerthy Suresh: Her National Award-winning performance in *Mahanati* affirmed her status as an acting star. Known to effortlessly juggle between Malayalam, Telugu and Tamil films

"South cinema is larger than life. It's a visual treat to just watch them. The kind of money they spend to build the scale of the film, how they shoot it, they are big screen entertainers"

—**ANIL THADANI**
Distributor of the Hindi-dubbed versions of Bahubali, Pushpa Part 1 *and the two* KGF *films*

